



In the Cans

The deadlock will postpone films such as *Main Aur Mrs Khanna*, *Kambakht Ishq* and *Kaminey*

- Producers want a **50:50 deal** between multiplexes and themselves for all films.
- 750 multiplex screens** nationwide contribute **40 per cent** of domestic theatrical revenue, which forms the largest chunk.
- Domestic revenue rose from **Rs 71.5 billion** to **Rs 80.2 billion**, contributing **73 per cent** to the total.
- Overseas theatrical and home video contribute **9 per cent** and **8 per cent** respectively.

SHAH RUKH KHAN AND AAMIR KHAN WITH THE UNITED FORUM



KAMINEY

2 is here as are the general elections. The FICCI-KPMG report on the film industry this year had predicted a slowdown based on IPI. Season 1's impact and the liquidity crunch, saying annual domestic theatrical revenue would come down from Rs 80.21 billion in 2008 to Rs 78.81 billion in 2009, though a few major releases, such as the Akshay Kumar-Kareena Kapoor starrer *Kambakht Ishq* and Vishal Bharadwaj's *Kaminey*, are about a month away.

For independent distributors, groaning under the loss of the repeat run business (not possible with movies such as *Singh is Kinng* running in 28 shows on a single day in a theatre like Cinemax in Versova, Mumbai) and the influx of big studios who tend to skim the cream off Mumbai and Delhi where an average of 80 per cent of all revenue comes from multiplexes, it is a battle they have been too fragmented to fight.

For the national multiplex chains like PVR, BIG Cinemas, Fame, Inox, Cinemax, Fun Republic and Movie Time, it is an unpleasant echoing of their own monopolistic stance with independent producers, who often have to accept any terms to get screen time. The producers want the same terms for every film, whether it stars Aamir Khan or Arshad Warsi. Their demand is that it be a 50 per cent share of revenue, whatever it is, week after week. But multiplexes also have a point, in that it was studios such as YashRaj Films that had demanded preferential treatment in 2006—for a 52 per cent revenue share for *Fanaa*.

Will the who-blinks-first-contest do more than put more money into the pockets of producers and distributors? Or will it end up correcting an overheated system where films were being bought by studios for stupendous

prices, driving independent distributors out of business? It may well have to. Already several projects are in re-think mode. Indian Films that was to have bought Vipul Shah's *London Dreams* has backed out, Eros has cut the budget of Salman Khan's *Veer*, Shree Ashtavinayak's big budget *Blue* has yet to find a distributor, and PVR Pictures has temporarily halted its productions. Several actors are choosing to do advertisements rather than do movies for less, for now, as overseas funding dries up. For producers this is also a self-protective measure with talk that multiplexes were intent on reducing their share to 42.5 per cent of the revenue by the year-end. Like most Bollywood films, this is likely to end in hugs and kisses rather than tears and recrimination, but the build-up is expected to be replete with melodrama. If only it could be filmed. ■